As in previous eras, information networks will struggle to find the right balance between truth and order. Some will opt to prioritise truth and maintain strong self-correcting mechanisms. Others will make the opposite choice. Many of the lessons learned from the canonisation of the Bible, the early modern witch hunts and the Stalinist collectivisation campaign will remain relevant, and perhaps have to be relearned. However, the current information revolution also has some unique features, different from – and potentially far more dangerous than – anything we have seen before.

Hitherto, every information network in history relied on human mythmakers and human bureaucrats to function. Clay tablets, papyrus rolls, printing presses and radio sets have had a far-reaching impact on history, but it always remained the job of humans to compose all the texts, interpret the texts and decide who would be burned as a witch or enslaved as a kulak. Now, however, humans will have to contend with digital mythmakers and digital bureaucrats. The main split in twenty-first-century politics might be not between democracies and totalitarian regimes but rather between human beings and non-human agents. Instead of dividing democracies from totalitarian regimes, a new Silicon Curtain may separate all humans from our unfathomable algorithmic overlords. People in all countries and walks of life – including even dictators – might find themselves subservient to an alien intelligence that can monitor everything we do while we have little idea what *it* is doing. The rest of this book, then, is dedicated to exploring whether such a Silicon Curtain is indeed descending on the world, and what life might look like when computers run our bureaucracies and algorithms invent new mythologies.